SD-005 — Customer Communication, Tone, and Status Update Guide

Document control

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TO: All Service Desk and IT Operations staff

FROM: Maria Chen, Service Desk Manager

DATE: March 14, 2025

SUBJECT: Communication standards for the upcoming quarter and beyond

Team,

Over the past quarter, I have reviewed a sample of our ticket communications, both in writing and in call recordings. I want to share what I found, what is working well, and what needs to improve.

What is working well: our resolution times continue to improve, and our CSAT score is at 4.5 out of 5. The team is doing good technical work and most of you are clearly communicating with users respectfully and clearly. Thank you for that.

What needs to improve: I have seen too many cases where a user is left without an update for days, or where a status update says "working on it" without any information about what is being worked on or when the user can expect an update. This is the single biggest driver of escalations to leadership that I see, and it is almost always avoidable.

Effective immediately, the following standards apply.

1. Every update tells the user three things

Every status update — whether a ticket comment, an email, or a chat message — must tell the user:

1. What is happening. "We have escalated this to the network team and they are investigating the VPN connectivity issue affecting your building."
2. What we need from the user, if anything. "We do not need anything from you at this time" is a valid answer and is required when no action is needed.
3. When the next update will come. "I will update you by 3 p.m. today, or sooner if we have news."

An update that says "still working on it" or "no update at this time" does not meet this standard. If there is no update, say what the team is currently doing — even if the answer is "we have not been able to reproduce the issue yet."

2. Acknowledge within the first-response target

Every ticket gets a first response within the target for its priority. The first response can be:

- A resolution
- An acknowledgment that we are investigating
- A request for additional information

If the first response is an acknowledgment, it still tells the user the three things above.

3. Do not promise what you cannot deliver

Do not promise a resolution time. Promise an update time, and meet it. A missed update time is worse than a long update interval — it tells the user they cannot trust what we say.

If you will miss an update time, send the update before the time you promised, even if the update is "no news yet, next update by 5 p.m."

4. Plain language

Use plain language. Avoid jargon, acronyms, and internal product names unless the user uses them first. Explain what a system is doing, not what the system's components are doing.

Instead of: "The SSL certificate has expired and needs renewal by the platform team."

Use: "The security certificate on the website has expired, which is why you are seeing the warning. Our platform team is renewing it and we expect it to be back to normal shortly."

5. Tone

We are professional, not formal. We are friendly, not casual. We are direct, not curt.

- Use the user's name in the first message
- Use contractions ("we're" not "we are") for readability
- Do not use emojis in ticket comments
- Do not use exclamation points except in genuine celebration ("your access is restored!")
- Apologize once, and only when we have caused the problem

"I'm sorry for the inconvenience" for every ticket — regardless of cause — teaches users to ignore our apologies. Apologize where the apology is meaningful.

6. Difficult conversations

When we cannot do what the user wants, say so clearly, once, and explain what we can do.

Do not say:

- "Unfortunately..." (used to soften a "no" but adds nothing)
- "As per my previous email..." (escalates tension)
- "That's not my job..." (accurate but not useful)
- "You'll need to..." (implies we are not helping)

Use:

- "Here is what I can do..."
- "The policy does not allow X, but here is another path..."
- "I understand why that is frustrating. Let me see what is possible."

7. Escalation language

When escalating, tell the user what escalation means.

Instead of: "I have escalated your ticket."

Use: "I have escalated this to our network team, who specialize in this kind of issue. They will take over investigation and I will remain your contact. Your next update will come by [time]."

8. Written communication templates

Templates are available in the knowledge base under SD-005 templates. Use them as a starting point, not as final text. Every message should read like it was written by a person, not copied from a template.

9. Measurement

Starting next month, I will be reviewing a sample of ticket communications every month and providing feedback. Your manager will also review your communications quarterly as part of your regular check-in.

The goal is not to catch anyone out — the goal is to raise the whole team's standard. If you are unsure whether a communication meets the standard, ask your shift lead before sending.

10. Questions

Bring questions to me directly or raise them at the weekly team meeting. I would rather talk about a difficult communication before it is sent than debrief a difficult one after.

Thank you for your work and for taking this seriously.

Maria

Related documents

- SD-001 Ticket Intake, Triage, and Priority Matrix
- SD-002 Escalation, Handoff, and Major Incident Communication
- SD-004 Knowledge Article Quality and Publishing Standard

Revision history

Version	Date	Change
2.0	09/12/2023	Annual refresh
2.3	March 14, 2025	Issued as memo; measurement section added